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PHILOSOPHY OF LANGUAGE:

Fundamental Concerns

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CHAPTER 1

LANGUAGE: ITS MEANING, FUNCTIONS AND EXPLANATION OF PHILOSOPHY OF LANGUAGE

MEANING OF LANGUAGE

It is important to point out right from the beginning that the English term "language" is surrounded with some ambiguities.

It has not just a single meaning. In trying to translate the English term "language" into French, for instance, we realize that it has three possible meanings: *langage*, *langue* and *parole*.

The English word "language" is very ambiguous because it expresses three different ideas. In the first place "language" refers to the general phenomenon of speech. In this sense the Latin use the term *oratio* and the French use *le langage*. Secondly, the term "language" is used to refer to the system of words and signs as a means of communication belonging to a particular nation or race, for example, Swahili, English, French, Igbo etc. This is the equivalent of *lingua* in Latin or *la langue* in French. This second sense is technically referred to as "tongue" or "natural language". Thirdly, the English term "language" refers to a particular utterance of a person, which is also often referred to as "talk" or "speech" (*sermo* in Latin and *parole* in French). Latin and French languages are the most precise in expressing these three different concepts in the sense that they employ different terms to depict each of the three concepts.

De Saussure¹ maintains that we do not confuse the general and abstract term "language" with the concrete language (*la langue*,

¹F. de Saussure, *Cours de linguistique générale*. (Paris: Oatit 1978), pp. 24-25. F. de Saussure is a world renowned Swiss linguist that is everywhere referred to as an authority in any matter concerning language.

lingua) of a given nation. Language in its abstract sense has physical, physiological and psychological dimensions. Being so general and abstract, its study is open to many disciplines like psychology, anthropology, philosophy etc. Language in its concrete sense, however, is a determined part of language as a social product necessitated by the need for social interaction. In this latter sense, language is conventionally invented by a given social group.²

* Gilbert Ryle distinguished between "Language" and "Speech". Language, according to him, is but the natural language like English, French, Latin, Igbo etc. It is "a stock, fund deposit of words."³ It is a system of communication between members of a given community. We are partly taught it and we partly pick it up. Speech, on the other hand, denotes "the activity or rather the clan of activities of saying things."⁴ While Language is a system or a deposit of words meant for communication in a given social community, Speech is the activity of making use of any or many of these systems or deposits. Language is a system, while Speech is an activity. Speech is like a trade, while Language is the capital for such a trade: "as Capital stands to Trade, so Language stands to Speech."⁴ While words are "atoms of Language...sentences are the units of Speech."⁵ When a person makes a mistake in Language he commits the language fault called solecism, but those who know the language well still understand him. On the contrary, error in Speech leads to "absurdity."⁶ It is absurd, for example, to say:

²*Ibid.*

³G. Ryle, "Use, usage and meaning." *Proceedings of the Aristotelian Society*, Suppl. vol. 35 (1961). Reprinted in G. Ryle, *Collected Papers*. (London: Hutchinson of London, 1971), p. 407

⁴*Ibid.*, p. 408

⁵*Ibid.*

⁶*Ibid.*, p. 410

“Mr. X knows that he (Mr. X) knows nothing.” This a contradiction. This type of error is what Ryle calls error in Speech, as distinguished from error in Language.

The Speech error is a logical error, while solecism is only an error in the proper use of a natural language or grammatical error. To say something without observing the rules of logic is to say something nonsensical and the speaker betrays not ignorance of grammar or vocabulary, but silliness. Speech is discourse and is the concern of logicians and philosophers. Therefore, Ryle’s term, “Language” is equivalent to Latin *lingua* or French *la langue*, while his term “Speech” is the equivalent of Latin *oratio* or French *le langage*. Some English writers adopt this distinction of Ryle. The term “language”, however, is still generally used to refer to Ryle’s Speech. If Ryle’s Speech were generally adopted, we would be talking of “Philosophy of Speech” and not “Philosophy of language.” In this book, we are studying language in its general sense, that is to say in the sense of Ryle’s Speech.

The following table of C. B. Buck gives us a clearer view of the difference between language as a generic term and language as system of communication belonging to a social group.

Greek	φωνη (λογος)	γλωσσα
Latin	oratio	lingua
French	langage	langue
German	Sprache	Sprache
English	language (speech)	language (“tongue”) ⁷

⁷C. B. Buck, *A Dictionary of Selected Synonyms in the Principal Indo-European Languages*. (London: The University of Chicago Press, 2949), p. 1259.

The interest of this book is first and foremost in language in its generic sense (*oratio, le lanage*). Natural languages (the systems of communication) of social groups (*leslangues*) and all the individual acts of speaking (*les paroles*) come under the general phenomenon of speech. In its generic sense, language is the abstraction of all the languages and all speech acts. In this generic sense, the term "language" includes more than verbal language. It includes such systems of representations and of communications like gestures, sign-languages, logical and mathematical symbols, down to religious symbols and road signs.

Definition of Language: There is no commonly accepted formal definition of the term "language". I subscribe to T. A. Harley's view that such a "formal definition of language is surprisingly elusive."⁸

①
By language I mean: All means of getting myself and/or my interlocutor informed. Language is a means of information, both interior and exterior information. Where there is no language, there is no information. A person can mope at an object without articulating his perception in a certain language. In such a situation, the person is not informed by what he looks at. As soon as he tries to make out certain information from what he looks at, he goes into a certain dialogue with the object before him. He employs certain genetic endowments and some already formed concepts and with the help of these he forms the concept of the present object of his perception. In doing so, he is already making use of a certain language. Wherever there is information language is at play. Language so perceived may

⁸ T. A. Harley, *The Psychology of Language: From Data to Theory*. (Erlbaum (UK): Taylor & Francis, 1995), p. 28

he said to bear much resemblance in scholastic epistemology. It is the abstraction of the universal knowledge possible. Without the agent without articulation, without abstraction language is not only oral speech and all natural signs and conventional signal, painting, symbol etc. In this sense language includes all forms of internal and external language has genetic and environmental sense that this book uses the term "language" stated. The concept of language avoids some extremities and narrow concepts of language.

Functions of Language

By 'functions of language' we mean the purposes of language. Language is so used to discuss its functions is not an easy task we shall examine those roles of language to some extent, obvious. There may be still more roles are known to some experts in linguistics, philosophy, science etc. I agree with the view that language is more subtle than language is, and has many different uses."⁹

It is important as philosophers that language because generally people use language in human life and activities. The relationship between language and reality because of the roles one school of thought has to language, as we shall see in chapter

⁹<https://philosophy.lander.edu/logic/formal-logic-25/8/20>

be said to bear much resemblance to the active/agent intellect in scholastic epistemology. It is the agent intellect that makes the abstraction of the universal possible, thus making knowledge possible. Without the agent intellect, a person sees without articulation, without abstraction. In this sense, language is not only oral speech and writings, but it includes all natural signs and conventional symbols: word, gesture, signal, painting, symbol etc. In this definition, language includes all forms of internal and external representation. Thus, language has genetic and environmental elements. It is in this sense that this book uses the term “language”, unless otherwise stated. The concept of language as means of information avoids some extremities and narrowness of the existing concepts of language.

Functions of Language

By ‘functions of language’ we mean the uses, the roles or purposes of language. Language is so complex and subtle that to discuss its functions is not an easy task. In this sub-chapter we shall examine those roles of language that are, to large extent, obvious. There may be still many uses of language that are known to some experts in linguistics, psychology, cognitive science etc. I agree with the view that “there is perhaps nothing more subtle than language is, and nothing has as many different uses.”⁹

It is important as philosophers that we study the functions of language because generally people undervalue the roles of language in human life and activities. The controversy about the relationship between language and thought persists mostly because of the roles one school of thought or the other assigns to language, as we shall see in chapter five. For instance, the

⁹https://philosophy.lander.edu/logic/form_lang.html (accessed on 25/8/20)

✍ expressionist school of thought is of the view that the function of language is limited just to communication or expression. As we shall see in this present chapter, communication is just one of the several functions of language. Functions of language cut across diverse sections of human activities, beginning from our thinking. Aristotle defines man as both *homo sapiens* (an intelligent or a thinking being) and *homo loquens* (a being endowed with language). Thought and speech are both basic faculties in man as a rational being. We can accomplish a lot by use of language.

Thinkers and scholars do not agree on the number of functions of language. Some (e.g., logicians) talk of three basic functions of language, some distinguish five functions, some (like Roman Jakobson a Russian American linguist) discusses six functions, while others (psychologists) are of the view that there are seven main functions of language. In this our study, we shall discuss the seven functions of language according to the school of thought that distinguishes seven functions of language, and we are adding some more functions to the seven. Our discussion will convince the reader that our additions are not just arbitrary.

The seven main functions of language studied by some experts in psychology are as follows: (1) **Expressive/Communicative** functions, (2) **Interpretative** functions, (3) **Control** function (4) **Remembering/Thinking** function, (5) **Discovery of One's Name** (6) **Social** functions and (7) **Creative** functions.¹⁰

i. ***Expressive/Communicative Functions:***

As we shall see in chapter five, those who guard the expressionist view about language believe that we use language to express to others the thoughts or ideas we have in our mind. In this sense, we use language to communicate to

¹⁰www.psychologydiscussion.net (accessed on 25/8/2020)

others our opinions or views about certain facts and events. There are scholars who say that language is used "to express a sudden change of state, fear, delight, pain or confusion" and that "such an expression is not a deliberate, conscious expression, but a spontaneous, immediate response not directed towards any other object."¹¹ One sees here special form of expression, which is more of expression of some psychological state of the speaker. In this special sense of expression, words are used to express attitudes and feelings which do not essentially deliver any particular information. It is more of expression of the speaker's emotion. Such expression is often in form of exclamation like "Wow!", "What a weather!"; "Boring!" Such expressions aim at expressing the feelings and impressions of the speaker and not in delivering any message.

It is not in this limited sense that we are using expression here. We can use language to express both our feelings, our understanding of state of affairs, our opinion and so on. Our usage of term "expression" actually includes communicating to others; this is a very important function of language, so important and known function of language in our interpersonal relation and interaction that some think that it is the sole function of language. We use language to communicate to others our thoughts, ideas and observations.

ii. *Interpretative Functions:*

We become aware of our environment through the information we get through our various senses, through what fellow humans have communicate to us or through our reflective thoughts. When such information comes to us, we compare it with the pieces of information we already have; that is to say, with our past knowledge and experiences, so as to understand the novel information. This comparing is done by means of

¹¹www.psychologydiscussion.net (accessed on 25/8/2020)

language and this is what we call interpretative function of language. Our environment, as it were, serves as stimulus to us and sends us into reflection during which interpretations take place.

To control behaviour

iii. *Control/Directive Function:*

This role is the use of language to control or to get attention of others. We can use language to induce certain actions or reactions from our audience. Under this function we can think of a command or a request. The directive function is a function of social control and interpersonal interaction. Asking someone to do something for us, like to wait for us or to assist us, we do so by control or directional use of language. We use language to control and influence the behavior of our addressee in a certain way. Thus, it is also called directive function, because we use language to give others some directive about what we want from them. Some people call it conative function and it is often in the form of imperative like "Stand up!"; "Get out!" It can also be in form of pleading or begging: "Could you assist me shift this table?"; "Please could you allow me deliver my lecture?"

Control function of language is usually directed to others, the audience or the interlocutor. Sometimes control language comes in form of exclamation like "Help!", "Danger!", "I am finished!"; "Is there nobody around!" Children often use their cry to direct and control the adult. We find it easier to control those we know their names than those we do not know theirs. For instance, the mere calling of a person's name in a noisy lecture hall controls the bearer of the name very much. Often when a person is doing something wrong and wants to run away on seeing someone coming, if the person coming calls his/her name, the perpetrator of the act stops running away.

iv. *Remembering/Thinking Function*:¹²

It is Ludwig Wittgenstein who asserts that "language is itself the vehicle of thought."¹³ In other words, language serves as means of thinking. We think in language. It is quite wrong to guard the opinion that we do not need language in thinking. I agree with the view thus expressed:

Imagine our being able to think and remember without the use of words. It is almost impossible to recall or remember or think without the use of words and therefore, language. It is language, which helps us to encode experiences, store them and retrieve and decode. It is language, which helps us to translate experiences into thought and engage in processes of different types.¹⁴

it actually means that the deaf & dumb are language

v. *Identification Function*

Self-identification goes with the consciousness of "I", "Me" "Mine", "Others", "Not Me" "They", "Their" etc. In children, self-identity and self-consciousness normally begins with the discovery of one's name and the names of others. This discovery is done by means of language; names themselves are language; they are words. The formation of self-consciousness is an essential aspect of the development of the self. This differentiates humans from brutes and a normal person from a mentally disturbed person.

In addition to the above, we can use language to tell people the part of the world or part of the country we come from and this influences the way they relate to us, for it helps them identify us all the more. Also, language reveals our identity naturally when we speak our mother tongues. It helps identify a person

¹²For a more elaborate treatment of the role of language in thinking see our chapter five below.

¹³L. Wittgenstein, *Philosophical Investigations*, tr. G.E.M. Anscombe (Oxford: Basil Blackwell, 1953), paragraph 329

¹⁴www.psychologydiscussion.net (accessed on 25/8/2020)

as a German, a French, an English, an Igbo, a Yoruba, an Ashanti etc. Once I was in Frankfurt International Airport in Germany; as I was passing I overheard a group of five young men conversing in my Nigerian mother tongue **Igbo**. I went to them and asked them some question in Igbo about the topic of their conversion. Their common first reaction was expression of embarrassment and surprise; the next was laughter, then followed hearty and warm welcome in the short statement: "*Nwannaa, nno.*" (Brother, you are welcome.) The language itself identified us without any effort on our own part. There and then by means of language we were able to identify ourselves as "We" and the rest as "They".

vi. *Social Functions of Language:*

This function of language follows from the last function we have just discussed.* Language performs a very important social function. We just saw that apart from promoting a sense of personal identity, language also serves as a means of developing a sense of social identity, ^{let's} a sense of belongingness to a particular group, marking out different degrees of social proximity and distance. Each and every one of us belongs to one social group or the other with its language. ^{or} Also, the social group has some traditions, culture and religion coded in the language of the group and these create and maintain sense of social identity for the group. This sense of social identity and belongingness reinforces efforts toward community development.

Among the social functions of language is what some linguists like Roman Jakobson call "phatic function." The end of phatic function is to maintain social relationships like to inspire conversations and pleasantries. Some people describe phatic talks as "elevator talk" or "warm up conversation" talks.

Examples of phatic language include “Good morning!”, “Hi!”, “Salute!”, “Bye!”

Such a kind of talk doesn’t provide us with any necessary information. It even doesn’t express our feelings, but it helps us to interact with people. Every time we meet somebody on the street, we can talk about the weather, or work, or children, it doesn’t matter. The real reason for such a talk is not our interest, but simply our desire to talk. Of course, such conversations may also contain some interesting information, but it’s not necessary.¹⁵

* Still on the social function of the language, it is in language that conversations, jokes and funs are made among people. Music, hymns and songs are composed in language and they serve as effective means of social integration, togetherness and cohesion. Religious praises, prayers and incantations are all in language. Social gatherings and meetings are organized and held by means of language.

vii. *Creative Functions:*

Language has the ability of eliciting thought in an individual. * Language plays a very crucial role in imaginative and creative activity, both intra-mental and extra-mental. It is, for example, by means of language that we write a novel, poetry and other forms of written works. Language makes it possible for us to engage in creative thought and imagination. Noam Chomsky refers to linguistic creativity as “the creative aspect of language use.”¹⁶ By this Chomsky means that “All humans have the ability to produce and understand an infinite number of novel sentences — sentences that are new in the linguistic experience of the speaker/hearer and perhaps also new in the history of

¹⁵<https://paper-due-now.com/essay-language-five-functions-language/> (accessed on 28/8/2020).

¹⁶Chomsky, 2002 [1966], 53

their language.”¹⁷ Many philosophers of language agree that there is “that aspect of language which enables a language user to use language in a novel way or to devise new forms of language.”¹⁸ This is the creative function of language. Creative function of language refers to the productive aspect of language which is “the ability to produce and understand an unlimited number of sentences that one has not previously encountered.”¹⁹ [The creative function of language refers to the fact that “there exists a capacity in language to move beyond the literal rules of syntax and semantics, as described in standard linguistic theory, and still produce a comprehensible utterance.”²⁰

viii. *Informative function*

Language serves both as a means of gaining information and giving information. When others speak, we get information from what they say; also we give them information by using language. By means of language message is got and is also communicated. The fact is that informative role of language has much to do with the communicative function of language. We get much information from voice, sign and symbolic languages. Even when we observe nature through our five senses, it is in language that we interpret and understand the information we get through the senses. We can thus see that informative function of language is among the most important roles of language.

¹⁷<https://eprints.utas.edu.au/21098/https://eprints.utas.edu.au/21098/> (accessed on 31/8/2020). Also confer Chomsky 2002 [1966], 5.

¹⁸<https://eprints.utas.edu.au/21098/https://eprints.utas.edu.au/21098/> (accessed on 31/8/2020)

¹⁹<https://eprints.utas.edu.au/21098/https://eprints.utas.edu.au/21098/> (accessed on 31/8/2020)

²⁰Ibid.

ix. *Performative Function*

It is the English philosopher, by name J. L. Austin, who popularizes the idea that we use language to accomplish different actions.²¹ According to Austin, there are three forms of action we normally accomplish by use of language: ① *speech* locutionary act, illocutionary act and perlocutionary ② *speech in activity* act.²² Locutionary act is the act of talking; it is the verbal activity itself. Illocutionary act is the performance of an act in saying something. For example, asking question, answering ③ *speech that has consequences* question, making promise, making a declaration, baptizing, condemning, blessing, cursing, teaching etc. Convention and authority are very important for the performance of certain illocutionary acts. Only authorized judge, for example, can condemn and only ordained ministers can baptize, and so on. Perlocutionary act: saying something will often produce certain consequential effects upon the *feelings, thoughts or actions* of the audience or of the speaker or of other persons. While speaking, the speaker can encourage, irritate, amuse, inspire, discourage, impress, distract, embarrass, scandalize, bore, attract attention, etc. To accomplish any of these acts in speech is perlocutionary act.²³

The pronouncements made by ministers of religion like "Take and eat, this is my body" said by a Catholic priest, or "I proclaim you husband and wife"; "I absolve you from your sins" etc. are all performative sentences. Also sentences handed down by judges following a verdict are performative because those words impose fines, penalties, or even death.

²¹ J. L. Austin, *How To Do Things With Word*. (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1971).

²² J.L. Austin, "Locutionary, Illocutionary, Perlocutionary" in *Basic Topics in the Philosophy of Language* Robert M. Harnish (ed.). (New York: Harvester Wheatsheaf, 1994), 30 – 39. Also see our chapter 2 above.

²³ See chapter 2 above.

Performative language can sometimes be so powerful that it is guarded by some rules. Hate speech, slander, libel, and defamation are considered powerful enough to actually do damage to a person or to an institution, such that to engage in such a language is considered a criminal offence in some countries.

x. *Aesthetic function*. Aesthetic function of language refers to how language is used to make manifest the beauty of a thing. This function does not have any particular purpose than to show the beauty of the use of language. Here words and sentences are considered as linguistic artefacts. This function serves neither as a request nor as a message. The aesthetic function helps us use words as a tool of a poetic art, and as certain signs. Here the beauty of chosen words and phrases is more important than usefulness of the information.²⁴ It is in poetry that the aesthetic function of language is most manifest.

xi. *Storage Function*

Storing thought, values, culture, information etc. by means of language has been in existence since the history of man. In the primitive age, such storage was by means of oral traditions in form of stories; through such stories thoughts, values and culture have been transmitted from generation to generation. Some archaic civilizations used drawings and paintings to store values and cherished information; such drawings and paintings are, of course, language in the broad sense. With the invention of writing and printing a serious revolution took place in the storage function of language. We can think here of the volumes of written and printed materials in all the libraries the world over. Yet another revolution took place recently in the storage role of language with the invention of computer. It is unimaginable the amount of information that can be stored in a

²⁴Leech (1974)

small-sized computer or any e-device. All these are done in language. Software is the computer language.

Another form of storage of information is the human memory. It is in language that we store the information in our memory. In fact, the computer memory is only an imitation of the human memory. Information is stored in the computer memory in form of software in imitation of the human language in which information is stored in the human memory.

xii. *Provocative Function*

Language can provoke thoughts, feelings and emotions both in ourselves and in our hearers. The user of language may or may not intentionally aim at such a provocation. It is a known fact that by use of language people try to incite others to certain actions and emotions. Some known politicians who are good in oratory use language to send their audience into streets to protest against their political opponents; comedians use both verbal and body languages to bring their audience into long laughter. Inspiring speeches, talks and sermons often make people engage in certain positive actions and projects.

As we have earlier said, the nature of language is so complex and subtle that to be able to discuss all its functions can be said to be an impossible task. We have tried here to discuss those functions of language that strike us. Further and deeper research can still make obvious some more functions of language.

What is Philosophy of Language?

Philosophy of language as a branch of philosophy is of recent origin, although the concern of philosophers with language is as old as philosophy itself, as can be seen in the works of Plato and Aristotle. As a branch of philosophy, philosophy of

language can be traced to the philosophical works of such people as Gottlob Frege, Bertrand Russell, G. E. Moore, Ludwig Wittgenstein, Logical Positivists and many other Anglo-Saxon analytic philosophers of 19th and 20th Centuries. We can thus say that philosophy of language, as we know it today, began in late 19th century and reached its climax in the early 20th century. It is of recent history.

The branch of philosophy called "Philosophy of Language" is not all that defined, because the philosophers who show interest in language do so for reasons that vary from one philosopher to another and from one school of thought to another, as we shall see in the next chapter. Thus, the problems concerning language dealt with by philosophers have no common link, except the fact that each has to do with language. What can be taken to be the subject matter of the philosophy of language is a collection of loosely knit concerns about language as it affects philosophy. Our next chapter is the survey of the various points within philosophy at which philosophers show some concern with language.

It is the view of some thinkers (for instance, the Logical Positivists) that the problem of philosophy is that of language. Thus, many philosophers, especially in the Contemporary period, opine that the primary, if not the sole, task of philosophy is that of the analysis of language. For this reason, analytic philosophy reigned supreme in the Contemporary period.

The concern for the analysis of language can be traced back to Socrates. Socrates' demand for proper definition of certain terms like "justice", "beauty" etc., was a demand for conceptual analysis. Aristotle's philosophical works also paid attention to the adequate definitions of terms like "cause",

“good”, “change” etc. For Socrates, Aristotle and other traditional philosophers, the conceptual analysis is meant to help us to arrive at an adequate conception of the structure of the world and an adequate standard for human conduct and social organization. An adequate understanding of the concept of “justice”, for instance, will enable people to be more just in their dealings with others, they seem to believe.

With the dawning of analytic philosophy in the late 19th C and early 20th C, there was a shift in the center of gravity of philosophical activity. Attention was shifted from the known object to the knowing mind and the language used in discussing reality. To the extent that philosophy consists of conceptual analysis, it is to that extent concerned with language. Therefore, as long as philosophy is thought of primarily as conceptual analysis, philosophy of language enjoys a central position in the theory of philosophical method.

Philosophy of Language as a recent discipline in philosophy is actually an interdisciplinary course cutting across philosophy, linguistics, psychology, computer science, artificial intelligence (AI) and all forms of cognitive sciences.